Form Helpers

Forms in web applications are an essential interface for user input. However, form markup can quickly become tedious to write and maintain because of the need to handle form control naming and its numerous attributes. Rails does away with this complexity by providing view helpers for generating form markup. However, since these helpers have different use cases, developers need to know the differences between the helper methods before putting them to use.

1 Dealing with Basic Forms

The most basic form helper is `form_tag`.

```
<%= form_tag do %>
  Form contents
<% end %>
```

When called without arguments like this, it creates a `<form>` tag which, when submitted, will POST to the current page. For instance, assuming the current page is `/home/index`, the generated HTML will look like this (some line breaks added for readability):

```
<form accept-charset="UTF-8" action="/" method="post">
  <input name="utf8" type="hidden" value="&#x2713;" />
  <input name="authenticity_token" type="hidden" value="J7CBxfHalt49OSHp27hblqK20c9PgwJ108n
/>
  Form contents
</form>
```

You'll notice that the HTML contains `input` element with type `hidden`. This `input` is important, because the form cannot be successfully submitted without it. The hidden input element has name attribute of `utf8` enforces browsers to properly respect your form's character encoding and is generated for all forms whether their actions are "GET" or "POST". The second input element with name `authenticity_token` is a security feature of Rails called **cross-site request forgery protection**, and form helpers generate it for every non-GET form (provided that this security feature is enabled). You can read more about this in the Security Guide.

1.1 A Generic Search Form

One of the most basic forms you see on the web is a search form. This form contains:

- a form element with "GET" method,
- a label for the input,
- a text input element, and
- a submit element.

To create this form you will use `form_tag`, `label_tag`, `text_field_tag`, and `submit_tag`, respectively. Like this:

```
<%= form_tag("/search", method: "get") do %>
  <%= label_tag(:q, "Search for:") %>
  <%= text_field_tag(:q) %>
  <%= submit_tag("Search") %>
<% end %>
```

This will generate the following HTML: